Rs 385 crore (their opponents insist it was more like Rs 600 crore). The Congress claims to have spent around Rs 300 crore ('We didn't have money left by April,' is what one party leader told me).

Yet the money game is only a slice of the story. The fact is, the BJP played it much smarter. While the Congress ad campaign began as early as January, the BJP put all its might into the final critical phase just ahead of the voting. They also, reportedly, managed to squeeze the television channels for better rates. 'Our plan was to completely take over the media space in the crucial one week before polling—that's when the voter is most influenced,' is how a BJP leader describes the media plan.

Indeed, it wasn't as if the ruling alliance didn't have money during its period in government. In the three years between 2011 and 2014, the ruling UPA spent more than Rs 400 crores on its flagship Bharat Nirman programme's publicity campaign; and Rs 187 crore were spent in its last year in office alone. The final thrust was planned by Tewari, who had become the information and broadcasting minister in October 2012, perhaps as a reward for his tireless attempts at defending the government on television as party spokesperson.

When the Bharat Nirman campaign was to be unveiled in May 2013, Tewari called some of us for a special screening. A slick short film had been prepared by Pradeep Sarkar, director of the film *Parineeta* and there was a song composed by Rajya Sabha MP and lyricist Javed Akhtar—*Meelon hum aye hain, meelon hamein jaana hai* (We have come a long way, we have a long way to go). The film radiated a feel-good factor—happy farmers, smiling youth, empowered women, along with a list of UPA achievements. 'So what do you think?' asked Tewari, anxiously. I didn't reply but muttered to myself, 'India Shining, Part 2!'

The fact is, for all its claims, the dominant narrative of the UPA-II government had been set—a weak leadership, corruption scandals, slow growth and inflation. No amount of glossy advertising was ever going to fundamentally change the storyline. Credibility was the issue and the UPA had already lost the perception battle. A spotty past record versus the promise of a shining future—the Congress versus BJP war had already been